The bigger burden was the famous surname, the assumption "that this guy would have in him some glowing chip from the old block". "And when they found that there was no such thing, only plain old wood, they felt a vague kind of disappointment," he says. "And I felt like a musically untuneful descendant of a maestro might, when expected to sing and being unable to produce even a whistle."

From Mahatma Gandhi's assassination to the rise of Indira Gandhi to the deaths of Jawaharlal Nehru and Lal Bahadur Shastri, multiple historic milestones are covered. Gandhi does not hesitate to criticise his own actions, nor those of his familiars. For instance, he writes of knowing that ballot boxes were stuffed in the 1971 election but being powerless to do anything. Or admitting his own desire to be president or vice-president ("I knew my failings, of which hankering for high positions was the greatest failing"). Elsewhere, he speaks of how Rajagopalachari, his maternal grandfather, became Congress chief minister, leading a minority government in Madras state in 1952, despite not having stood for election. "What happened was clever; it was not clean," he writes. "The crown snatched and slanted, sat ill on Rajaji's sage brow." Why did he choose to criticise family? "My grandfathers were extraordinary men, but at the same time, were ordinary mortals too, as fallible as they were great," he says. "Their greatest asset was that they knew this to be the case."

FROM GANDHI'S ASSASSINATION **TO THE RISE OF INDIRA TO THE DEATHS OF NEHRU AND SHASTRI**, MULTIPLE HISTORIC MILESTONES ARE COVERED

Gandhi's stints working with the president and vice-president, and later as Bengal governor, offer intimate glimpses into how power and democracy operate at the highest level. How political egos clash and constitutional functionaries navigate choppy waters. Decorum and decency prevailed in politics once, if Gandhi is to be believed. But he parries a question on why there seems to be less of both today. "Political fraud can be found out by Indians very, very quickly," he says. "And thanks to the election system having been mastered by us, politics in India can stay 'decent' with the opposite of 'decent' getting called out."

To read *The Undying Light* is to ride a rollercoaster—India is both wonderful and savage, chaotic and sublime. In the ultimate analysis, is Gandhi optimistic about the country? "I am optimistic about India for the reason that I have faith in the 'ordinary' Indian, who is really very extraordinary in her or his ability to rise above the disillusionments, frustrations and misfortunes of the day stoically and says, with Iqbal, *'kuchh baat hai ki hasti mitati nahin hamari...'*. I cannot define that *'kuchh baat'* but I believe in it, and am a devotee of it." ■

—Bhavya Dore



SHAMANS OF THE HIMALAYAS
By Anu Malhotra
OM BOOKS
₹595; 388 pages

matic segments, each exploring different facets of Himalayan shamanism: divine possession, oracular guidance, mass exorcism and the worship of nature spirits. Interspersed with revealing photographs and film stills from her documentation of trances and spirit possessions, the book brings to life a functioning social infrastructure where deities are consulted on everything from marriage dates to illnesses to job prospects. The shamans—or Goors—emerge as cultural anchors: part priest, part healer, part psychospiritual guide.

Malhotra's documentation of spirit possession rituals and divination ceremonies brims with cinematic vividness, yet never sacrifices scholarly depth for dramatic effect. The real takeaways of the book are its in-depth historical study of divine possession across cultures; a granular explanation of nature spirits, with specific references from ancient Indian texts and cultural tradition; and a chapter on spirit illnesses that provides an academically rigorous discussion on the inexplicable evil spirit afflictions from a socio-psychological perspective.

What elevates *Shamans of the Himalayas* beyond cultural documentation is its refusal to exoticise. Malhotra neither idealises nor dismisses what she calls "a coherent system of belief"—one that binds the individual to community, ancestry and the natural world. In a world increasingly disconnected from the sacred, Malhotra has given us a roadmap back to wonder. ■

—Bandeep Singh